DC TELEVISION UNIVERSE

(DCTVU)

FRANCHISE BIBLE — VOLUME 01: FOUNDATIONS

Alternate History — Story Present: Monday, January 4, 2010

Internal development document. Locked reference for all future series, crossovers, casting, and timeline entries.

Locked Franchise Fact	Status
Name: DC Television Universe (DCTVU)	LOCKED
Role: fills the place of BOTH the DCU and the Arrowverse in this alternate history	LOCKED
Source material: Marvel Comics characters, 100% comic-book accurate and faithful	LOCKED
Structure: shared fictional multiverse — 6 live-action series + 2 animated series	LOCKED
Connective tissue: crossing over plot elements, settings, cast and characters	LOCKED
No-Nerf Charter: absolutely nobody is nerfed	LOCKED
Story told through Hollywood media articles/headlines, social media, the internet, and screenplay-format dialogue	LOCKED
Timeline uses exact dates/times; ages calculated from real birthdays	LOCKED
All deliverables are produced as PDFs only	LOCKED
Fictional actors (created by the user) coexist with real-life actors	PENDING — user
The individual TV series	PENDING — user

1. Serialized vs. Standalone: The Perfect Balance

Recommendation: 65% serialized / 35% standalone, delivered as a hybrid in which almost every episode does both at once.

A pure case-of-the-week show can't support a universe where continuity is "extremely important," and a fully serialized show can't fill 22 episodes a year without padding. The answer that 2010-era network hits like *Smallville*, *Lost*, *Fringe*, and *Supernatural* were moving toward is the **A-plot / arc-plot hybrid**:

- **A-plot (standalone):** a villain, mission, or crisis that starts and is resolved within the hour. A casual viewer can drop in on any episode.
- **B/C-plots (serialized):** character relationships, secret identities, government pressure, and the season's "Big Bad" move forward every week. Nothing resets.
- **Consequences carry forward:** injuries, deaths, broken friendships, destroyed buildings, and public opinion all persist across episodes *and across series*.

22-Episode Season Rhythm

Episodes	Function	Serialized Weight
1–2	Two-part premiere: re-establishes the status quo, introduces the season's Big Bad	Heavy (~85%)
3–6	Villain-of-the-week episodes that each plant an arc clue	Light (~45%)
7–8	November sweeps: annual DCTVU crossover event	Heavy (~90%)
9–10	Midseason finale in December, ending on a cliffhanger	Heavy (~80%)
11–15	Winter run: standalones that deepen the mythology, plus a 'bottle' episode	Medium (~55%)
16–17	February sweeps: mini-arc / second crossover or backdoor pilot	Heavy (~75%)
18–19	Mostly standalone 'calm before the storm'	Medium (~50%)
20–22	May finale run: three-part climax that sets up next season and the shared universe	Heavy (~95%)

Continuity Safeguards

- **DCTVU Continuity Desk:** one franchise story editor who signs off on every script across all 8 series.
- **Master Timeline:** a single dated timeline (day, month, year, and time where it matters). Every episode gets an in-universe air date.
- **Universe Bible:** canonical power sets, secret identities, who knows whom, who knows which secrets, locations, and tech.
- **Crossover Calendar:** locked 18 months ahead so the series never contradict each other.
- **Ripple Rule:** a major event on one series (a death, a reveal, a destroyed landmark) must be acknowledged on every affected series within 2 aired weeks.
- **Animated canon:** both animated series are fully in continuity, set either on the prime Earth or on defined alternate Earths in the multiverse.

2. Genre, Subgenres, Rating and Runtime

Umbrella genre: superhero action-drama. Each series gets its own subgenre identity so the franchise never feels like the same show eight times.

Subgenre	Tone / Reference Point	Natural Fit
Science-fiction action	High-tech spectacle, military-industrial intrigue	Iron Man, Ant-Man, Wasp, Fantastic Four
Mythic / epic fantasy	Gods, realms, prophecy, Shakespearean family drama	Thor, Inhumans, Defenders (Namor)
Political / social allegory drama	Civil rights, fear of the 'other', registration debates	X-Men
Family adventure / exploration	Wonder, discovery, the family unit	Fantastic Four
Supernatural / cosmic horror	The occult and the multiverse	Doctor Strange / Defenders
Street-level crime drama	Grounded, urban, procedural	Heroes for Hire
Espionage / conspiracy thriller	Moral grey, double-crosses	Thunderbolts, S.H.I.E.L.D. threads
Space opera	Far-future, interstellar war	Guardians of the Galaxy (1969)
Coming-of-age teen drama	Legacy, identity, first love	Young Avengers, junior X-Men

Rating

Format	Rating	Why
Live-action series	**TV-14** (with V and L descriptors as needed)	Lets the No-Nerf Charter show the real stakes of comic-accurate violence while staying network-friendly in 2010. Edgier series (Heroes for Hire, Thunderbolts, Defenders' occult episodes) push to the top of TV-14.
Animated series	**TV-PG** (FV)	Stays in continuity with live action without softening the stakes. TV-Y7 would force nerfed fights.

Runtime

Format	Slot	Actual Runtime
Live-action episode	60-minute network slot	**42–44 minutes** (classic 2010 broadcast act structure: teaser + 5 acts)
Live-action pilots / crossover finales	Special 90–120 min event slot	64–88 minutes
Animated episode	30-minute slot	**22 minutes** (cold open + 2 acts)

3. Episode Count: Back to Our Roots

Recommendation: 22 episodes per live-action season, 26 episodes per animated season.

- **22 episodes** is the classic American network season (September premiere → May finale). It gives room for standalone adventures, character-focused episodes, and crossovers without rushing the arc.
- **26 episodes** for animation follows the classic syndicated Saturday-morning / weekday-afternoon model (two 13-episode blocks), which gives enough room to adapt full comic sagas faithfully.
- Eight series × a full season = **184 hours of DCTVU content per year** (6 × 22 live-action + 2 × 26 animated), a weekly presence comparable to the real-world Arrowverse at its peak.
- **Staggered launches** are recommended (the user will decide the series and order) so the shared universe is built up step by step rather than all at once.

Broadcast Calendar (Template)	Dates
Season premieres	Mid-to-late September / early October
November sweeps crossover	First 3 weeks of November
Midseason finales	Early-to-mid December
Winter premieres	Mid-to-late January
February sweeps event	February
May sweeps / season finales	Mid-to-late May
Upfronts (renewals, new series, trailers)	Mid-May, New York City
San Diego Comic-Con panels	July

4. The No-Nerf Charter

Rule: threats get scaled up; heroes never get scaled down. Every character uses the powers, skill, and intelligence they have in the source material. The only limits allowed are the ones the comics themselves set.

- **Comic-accurate weaknesses only.** Examples: the early Thor/Donald Blake 60-second rule when separated from Mjolnir; Iron Man's chest-plate heart condition in the original era; the Human Torch's flame limits in a vacuum and around water; Ben Grimm's transformation as a tragedy rather than a gift.
- **No 'convenient' depowering** to save on VFX. If the budget can't cover a feat on screen, the writers stage the scene differently (aftermath shots, practical effects, a cut to reaction shots) without lowering the character's power level.
- **Intelligence counts as a power.** Reed Richards, Tony Stark, Hank Pym, Hank McCoy, and Bruce Banner are written as the geniuses they are in the comics.
- **Power growth follows the comics** (e.g., Bobby Drake's Omega-level potential, Jean Grey's road to the Phoenix, Pym's size-changing range) and is tracked in the Universe Bible.

5. The Premier Team: THE AVENGERS

Recommendation: The Avengers, using their original Avengers #1 (September 1963) founding roster, with Captain America added in line with *Avengers* #4 (March 1964).

Why the Avengers: they are "Earth's Mightiest Heroes," the team built for a shared universe. Every founder can carry a series or a strong recurring role, and the team naturally connects every corner of the franchise: science (Iron Man, Ant-Man, Wasp), myth (Thor), monster/tragedy (Hulk), and legacy (Captain America).

Hero	Identity	Comic-Accurate Power Set (No Nerf)	First Team Appearance
Iron Man	Anthony "Tony" Stark	Powered armor: flight, repulsors, unibeam, super-strength, adaptive tech; genius-level engineer and industrialist	Avengers #1 (1963)
Thor	Thor Odinson (in the guise of Dr. Donald Blake)	Asgardian god of thunder: godlike strength and durability, weather and lightning control, Mjolnir (flight, energy, dimensional travel)	Avengers #1 (1963)
Hulk	Dr. Robert Bruce Banner	Strength without limit that increases with rage, near-invulnerability, regeneration, leaping for miles	Avengers #1 (1963)
Ant-Man / Giant-Man	Dr. Henry "Hank" Pym	Size-shifting via Pym Particles (shrink to insect size / grow to giant size), cybernetic ant communication, genius biochemist	Avengers #1 (1963); Giant-Man from #2
The Wasp	Janet van Dyne	Shrinking, insect wings for flight, bio-electric 'wasp's sting' blasts; tactician who named the team	Avengers #1 (1963)
Captain America	Steven "Steve" Rogers	Super-Soldier Serum: peak human strength, speed, endurance; master tactician and combatant; vibranium-alloy shield	Avengers #4 (1964)

Planned Expansion (comic-accurate order)

- **"Cap's Kooky Quartet" (Avengers #16, 1965):** Hawkeye (Clint Barton), Quicksilver (Pietro Maximoff), Scarlet Witch (Wanda Maximoff), led by Captain America. Ideal for a second-generation lineup.
- **Comic-accurate story beats to adapt:** the Hulk leaving the team (Avengers #3), Cap found frozen in ice (#4), Pym becoming Giant-Man (#2), the Masters of Evil (#6), Kang the Conqueror (#8), Wonder Man (#9).

6. Supporting Teams and Original Rosters

Each supporting team brings a different genre, location, and corner of the multiverse, and each uses its **original comic-book founding roster**. Characters who belong to more than one team (e.g., the Hulk with the Avengers and the Defenders; the X-Men's Angel and Iceman with the Champions) are a deliberate crossover hook, just as they are in the comics.

THE X-MEN

Original roster source: The X-Men #1 (September 1963)

Mutants feared and hated by the world they protect. Political allegory and the franchise's strongest source of serialized drama.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Professor X	Charles Xavier	World's most powerful telepath; founder and mentor
Cyclops	Scott Summers	Optic blasts of concussive force; field leader
Marvel Girl	Jean Grey	Telekinesis (later telepathy, then the Phoenix Force)
Beast	Dr. Henry "Hank" McCoy	Superhuman agility and strength, genius intellect
Angel	Warren Worthington III	Feathered wings, flight, enhanced vision and stamina
Iceman	Robert "Bobby" Drake	Cryokinesis; Omega-level potential

THE FANTASTIC FOUR

Original roster source: Fantastic Four #1 (November 1961)

Marvel's First Family. Science adventure, exploration, and the gateway to the cosmic and multiversal side of the DCTVU.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Mister Fantastic	Dr. Reed Richards	Stretching/elasticity; one of Earth's greatest minds
Invisible Girl	Susan "Sue" Storm	Invisibility, later force fields (comic progression)
Human Torch	Johnny Storm	Pyrokinesis, flame form, flight, nova flame
The Thing	Benjamin "Ben" Grimm	Rock-skinned body, immense strength and durability

THE DEFENDERS

Original roster source: Marvel Feature #1 (December 1971); Silver Surfer joins in The Defenders #2 (1972)

The 'non-team' of loners. Mystic, cosmic, and undersea threats. The franchise's supernatural wing.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Doctor Strange	Dr. Stephen Strange	Sorcerer Supreme in training/active; mystic arts, astral projection
Namor	Namor McKenzie, the Sub-Mariner	Atlantean king: strength, flight, aquatic powers
The Hulk	Dr. Bruce Banner	Shared with the Avengers (comic-accurate dual membership)
Silver Surfer	Norrin Radd	Power Cosmic: matter/energy manipulation, near-light-speed flight

THE INHUMANS (Royal Family)

Original roster source: Fantastic Four #45 (December 1965)

A hidden royal dynasty in Attilan. Palace intrigue, Terrigen Mists, and Shakespearean succession drama.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Black Bolt	Blackagar Boltagon	King; his voice can level mountains, so he stays silent
Medusa	Medusalith Amaquelin	Queen; prehensile, super-strong hair
Karnak	Karnak Mander-Azur	Finds the weak point in anything; martial arts master
Gorgon	Gorgon Petragon	Hooved legs that create seismic shockwaves
Triton	Triton Mander-Azur	Amphibious; underwater operative
Crystal	Crystalia Amaquelin	Control of the four classical elements
Lockjaw	—	Giant teleporting dog

HEROES FOR HIRE

Original roster source: Power Man and Iron Fist #48–50 (1977–78)

Street-level heroes for pay in New York. This team gives the DCTVU its grounded, Arrowverse-style corner.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Power Man	Luke Cage (Carl Lucas)	Unbreakable skin, superhuman strength
Iron Fist	Daniel "Danny" Rand	Kung fu master; chi-powered Iron Fist
Misty Knight (ally)	Mercedes Knight	Ex-NYPD detective, bionic arm
Colleen Wing (ally)	Colleen Wing	Samurai-trained swordswoman

THE THUNDERBOLTS

Original roster source: The Incredible Hulk #449 (January 1997)

Villains disguised as heroes. Espionage and redemption thriller with the best twist in Marvel history.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Citizen V	Baron Helmut Zemo	Master strategist and swordsman; secret leader
MACH-1	Abner Jenkins (the Beetle)	Armored flight suit and weapons
Songbird	Melissa Gold (Screaming Mimi)	Sonic constructs and sonic scream
Techno	Paul Norbert Ebersol (the Fixer)	Tech genius; cybernetic body
Atlas	Erik Josten (Goliath)	Size and strength increase via ionic energy
Meteorite	Dr. Karla Sofen (Moonstone)	Moonstone powers: flight, intangibility, energy blasts

GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY (Original)

Original roster source: Marvel Super-Heroes #18 (January 1969)

The 31st century of an alternate Earth. Space opera that defines the DCTVU multiverse.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Major Victory	Vance Astro	Telekinesis; 1,000-year-old astronaut in a containment suit
Charlie-27	Charlie-27	Jovian genetically engineered strength and durability
Martinex	Martinex T'Naga	Plutonian crystal body; heat and cold blasts
Yondu	Yondu Udonta	Centaurian archer; sound-controlled Yaka arrows

YOUNG AVENGERS

Original roster source: Young Avengers #1 (April 2005); first-arc lineup

The next generation, tied to the founders' legacies. A coming-of-age legacy drama for the franchise's later years.

Codename	Identity	Comic-Accurate Powers / Role
Iron Lad	Nathaniel Richards (young Kang)	Neuro-kinetic armor
Patriot	Elijah "Eli" Bradley	Super-soldier abilities, shield-fighter
Asgardian / Wiccan	William "Billy" Kaplan	Reality-warping magic
Hulkling	Theodore "Teddy" Altman	Shapeshifting Kree-Skrull hybrid
Hawkeye	Katherine "Kate" Bishop	Master archer and fencer
Stature	Cassandra "Cassie" Lang	Pym Particle size-shifting

Reserve Teams (ready for later seasons)

Team	Original Roster Source	Founding Members
Alpha Flight	Uncanny X-Men #120 (1979)	Guardian, Shaman, Snowbird, Northstar, Aurora, Sasquatch
The Champions	The Champions #1 (1975)	Hercules, Black Widow, Ghost Rider, Angel, Iceman
New Warriors	The New Warriors #1 (1990)	Night Thrasher, Nova, Firestar, Marvel Boy, Namorita, Speedball

7. Summary of Recommendations

Question	Answer
Serialized vs. standalone	65% serialized / 35% standalone, hybrid A-plot + arc-plot structure, overseen by a franchise Continuity Desk
Genre	Superhero action-drama, with a distinct subgenre for each series
Rating	Live action: TV-14. Animation: TV-PG.
Runtime	Live action: 42–44 min (60-min slot). Animation: 22 min (30-min slot).
Episodes per season	Live action: 22. Animation: 26.
Premier team	The Avengers — Iron Man, Thor, Hulk, Ant-Man/Giant-Man, Wasp (Avengers #1, 1963) + Captain America (#4, 1964)
Supporting teams	X-Men, Fantastic Four, Defenders, Inhumans, Heroes for Hire, Thunderbolts, Guardians of the Galaxy (1969), Young Avengers
Reserve teams	Alpha Flight, Champions, New Warriors
Power levels	No-Nerf Charter: comic-accurate powers and weaknesses only
Pending (user)	Fictional actors; the 6 live-action and 2 animated series